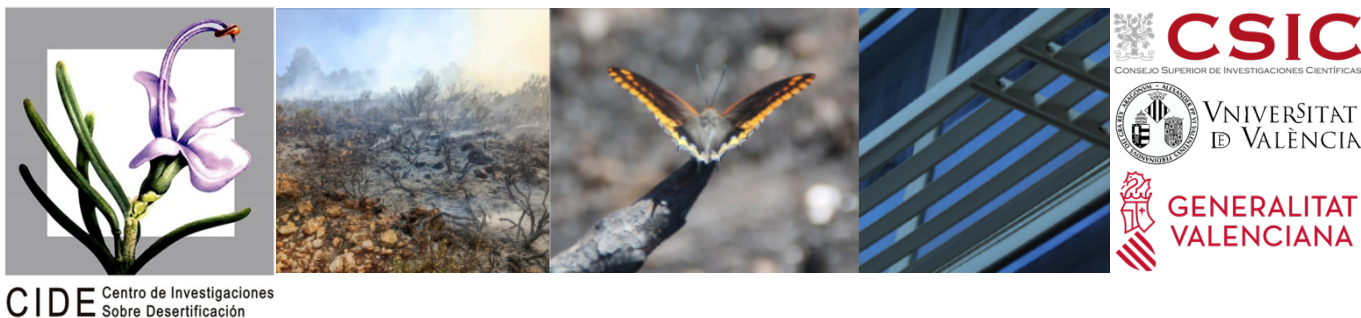




PhD position on Freshwater – Terrestrial Interaction and Ecosystem Functions

Full time | 46113 Moncada (Valencia) | Starting date 1st January 2027

The **Department of Ecology and Global Change** at the Desertification Research Centre (CIDE-CSIC) invites applications for a **pre-doctoral research position** funded by the DEGENT program of the Generalitat de Valencia.

About the project

The PhD will be part of **WaterLand**, a project investigating how biodiversity–ecosystem functioning (BEF) relationships operate across freshwater and terrestrial ecosystems. The project focuses on allochthonous organic matter (i.e., plant-derived inputs from surrounding terrestrial vegetation) and examines how these subsidies affect soil microbial functioning and shape ecosystem processes in Mediterranean landscapes. Mediterranean regions are biodiversity hotspots but highly vulnerable to global change. Within these landscapes, ponds are abundant and ecologically crucial, contributing to carbon storage, flood regulation, pollination support, and providing habitat for diverse taxa. Despite their importance, small water bodies remain underrepresented in BEF research, particularly in cross-ecosystem contexts.

We are looking for creative and dedicated applicants with experience in experimental ecology and enthusiasm for learning about the impacts of global change on freshwater ecosystem functioning, biodiversity, and cross-ecosystem interactions. The successful candidate will combine experiments and field observations. More information on the project can be found here: <https://mariacuenca-cambronero.github.io/WaterLand.html>

Your responsibilities

The project will be developed along a transect of sampling points from south of Valencia to north of Catalunya. This will be conducted as an intensive sampling campaign in May 2027, including collection of pond sediments, water samples, biodiversity, ecosystem functions, leaf litter, and terrestrial vegetation biodiversity. We expect the candidate to take the initiative in the sampling campaigns. Additionally, we will run a mesocosm experiment over the course of the PhD program, in which she/he will participate.

We expect that the candidate:

- Develop initiative through laboratory and field campaigns.
- Investigate the BEF interactions in response to Global Change.
- Study the terrestrial-freshwater linkages, focusing on how terrestrial vegetation affects water-soil bacterial communities.

- Participate in national and international conferences.
- Undertake international research stays to expand technical skills and collaborations.

Your profile

- BSc and MSc in biology or ecology, aquatic or environmental sciences, or related fields.
- Knowledge of aquatic ecology, including impacts of climate change and human pressures on freshwater ecosystems.
- Experience with freshwater biodiversity, including macrophytes, zooplankton, macroinvertebrates or amphibians.
- Experience in zooplankton or macroinvertebrate taxonomy would be a plus.
- Knowledge of statistical approaches and R programming.
- Excellent English skills for oral and written communication, and a willingness to learn Spanish.
- Enthusiasm to collaborate in a team of aquatic and terrestrial scientists, at the national and international level.

What we offer

We offer a position in a highly motivated team of international researchers, a friendly work environment, and access to state-of-the-art infrastructure. The CIDE-CSIC centre is located in the Moncada Institute and is projected to move to the Burjassot campus in the coming years.

The position is a full-time, four-year contract following the Spanish public-sector salary scheme. In a dynamic scientific environment. The Doctorate program would be integrated at the University of Valencia ([link](#)), which also offers training opportunities for PhD students and a supportive community of PhD students at CIDE-CSIC. The CIDE-CSIC centre is committed to diversity, and we welcome all qualified applications, regardless of gender, sexual orientation, nationality, belief, or disability.

Valencia is known for its high quality of life and standard of living. The Turia River park offers many outdoor opportunities, and the nearby sea caters to many summer activities. Valencia offers many cultural and gastronomic activities. The city also has an international airport, which is convenient when needed.

How to apply

- **The submission deadline is 11th October.**
- **The starting date is early 2027** (ideally 01/01/2027), but can be adjusted by mutual agreement.
- The position will be for four years, full-time.

Interviews will be held in mid-October, with final decisions made at the end of October.

Submit your application as a single PDF to Maria Cuenca (maria.cuenca@uvic.cat). Include the following in your application:

- A cover letter explaining your interest in the position.
- Your CV including your experience in ecology or related fields
- A copy of your MSc diploma and courses taken.
- Names, institutional affiliations, email addresses, and phone numbers of two references. Support letters are welcome.